PERSPECTIVES ON CONTEMPORARY LEGEND

NICOLAE CONSTANTINESCU

Until not so long time ago, the study of the contemporary legend seemed to be a rathen American or Anglo-Saxon speciality, as the previous eleven conferences of the ISCLR were held in North America or Great-Britain, the editors and most of the contributors of the first volumes of the publication *Perspectives on Contemporary Legend*[1] were from the same geographic area, and the genre itself seemed to be deeply rooted and widely spread in this cultural space. It is now, for the first time, when the ISCLR Conference steps on the Continental Europe, in France, due, mainly, to the conjugated efforts of Véronique Campion-Vincent, of the Maison des Sciences de l'Home in Paris, and Mark Glazer, of the Department of Psychology and Anthroppology of the University of Texas, U.S.A., the co-chairpersons of the meeting.

Innitially scheduled for four full days (eight sessions of four papers each), a fifth day was needed in order to cover the large number of participants registred for this major scientific event. The 34 papers read in the conference covered a wide range of subjects, divided into six main sessions: *Theoretical Issues in Contemporary legend* (2); *Literature, Art and the Contemporary Legend* (1); *Satanism, Abuse and the Contemporary Legend* (1); *Medicine and the Contemporary Legend* (1); *Case Studies* (4); *Index, Research and Film* (1).

To the, traditionally, by now, most numerous Anglo-American participants (the Canadians and Australians included), a large number of European scholars added. Besides some 'old, I mean wellknown 'combatants' like Bengt af Klintberg (Sweden), Rolf Brednich (Germany), Peter Burger (the Netherlands), Ingo Schneider (Austria), Véronique Campion-Vincent and Jean-Bruno Renard (France), some other cultural areas were attracted toward this fascinating topic as, for instance, Italy (Paolo Toselli), Israel (Benjamin Beit-Hallahmi), Romania (Nicolae Constantinescu). This comes to prove (if necessary) that the 'genre' as well, the contemporary legend, does exist one may say all over the world, but the scientist were not interested, did not collect and did not study it to the same extent as it was done in the above mentioned areas.

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[1] The Twelfth International Conference of the International Society for Contemporary Legend Research (ISCLR), Paris (France), 18—22 July, 1994.

On the other hand, it must be noticed that the 'object' (contemporary legend) is often taken in a very personal way, depending on the purpose of the study and on the scholar's own perspective — sociology, psychology, psychiatry, psychotherapy, literature, folklore, ethnology, communication, sociolinguistics, history, mentalities etc. In fact, when discussing the theory of the contemporary legend, there is a kind of a 'gentelmen agreement', but when dealing with the 'thing'/ 'text'/'narrative', it seems to be so multiform, slippery and everchanging so that everyone feels free to do whatever he/she wants to do with this 'object'. As a „friend-of-a-friend (FOAF) tale", the contemporary legend belongs to everyone and to nobody, to every place and to no place, to the remote time and to the nowadays as well. It is why, even when discussing some case studies, the papers and the comments turned over general but essential questions such as: the relationship of legend and reality (Brian McConnel, Nicolae Constantinescu), legend and ambiguity (Gillian Bennett), legend and group identity (Gary Alan Fine & Jeff Victor), legend as a process (Bengt af Klintberg), legend and rumors (Oliviane Brodin), new and old behaviour patterns and narrative responses (Benjamin Beit-Hallahmi), traditional world-view and contemporary popular culture (Gary R. Butler), *Are the Terms 'Modern' and 'Contemporary' Synonymous?* (Jacqueline Simpson) etc. And even broader arose the questions: Why do people tell such stories? What is the use of it? How does legend 'work' in our society? Here are some answers: "...the legend (of the 'Bosom Serpent') persisted in tradition because it allows people suffering from a number of complaints to visualise, understand and describe their symptoms to themselves and others"; "the legends are thus a language in which the efficacy of traditional versus conventional remedies may be explored and evaluated" (Gillian Bennet, *Medical Aspects of 'The Bosom Serpent' Legend);* "the basis for most of this violence (depicted in the C. L.) is the anxiety created by features of modern life and culture which are reflected in these stories; ...it is the fear these acts of violence stir up that make the contemporary legend and dynamic and convincing" (Mark Glazer, *Proscription, Violence and Contemporary Legend);* "the function of many legends is to give concret shape, in the form of an example, to the people's feelings of uneasiness about foreign elements in their daily life, elements that rightfully or not are seen as threats to their security" Bengt af Klintberg, *The Functions of Legend Narration in the Modern World);* "the contemporary legends are caused by our society's fears for whatever we don't know of, and thus we are afraid to be harmed by" (Lucia Veccia, *Classification and Cataloguing of Contemporary Legends: An Italian Example).*

And, my Lord!, there is so much 'fear', 'anxiety', 'threat' around us: AIDS (Genevieve Paicheler, *Legends about the Origins of AIDS in the French Public: From Conjectures to Certainty),* UFO (Mark Moravec, *Legends, Memorates and Mythologies: the Case of UFO Folklore);* kidnapping (Paolo Toselli, *Child Kidnapping and the Body Parts Black Market);* food contamination (Oliviane Brodin, *Individual Dif-*

ferences in Sensitivity to Food Contamination Rumors: An Experiment about Two Rumors on Leader of Food Products), racism (Véronique Campion-Vincent, *Sharing by Error: An Overview of the Short Films;* Robert M. MacGregor, *Steatopygia, Rolypoly Bums: Spike Lee and the Liz Claiborne Rumor); satanism* (Gary Alan Fine & Jeff Victor, *Satanic Tourism: Adolescent Dabblers and Identity Work;* Bill Ellis, *Satanic Ritual Abuse Claims as Contemporary Legend: Second Thoughts),* sex and sex-abuse (Peter Burger, *The Maculate Conception: Legend of Impregnation and Childbirth;* Jean-Bruno Renard, *Truth from the Mouth of Babes),* wars (Thomas E. Barden & John Provo, *Contemporary Legends and Belief Tales of the Vietnam War);* poverty and empty expectations (Nicolae Constantinescu, *Treasure-Hunting and Fortune-Making Stories in a 'Transition' Society);* street/road violence; work accidents Sigrid Schmitt, *The Worker Built-In the Oker Dam in Germany)* etc. All these feed the contemporary legend and make the genre everlasting. And not less the study of it. For, if "we are lived by the story", if „we can avoid these harmful situations as we are all potential victims" (Mark Glazer), then the study of the contemporary legend is not a mere scholarly demonstration of skills and erudition, but a possible tool in coping with the everyday difficulties of our life. We must be, however, aware of not „prioritizing our meaning" (Gillian Bennett), of assuring a high level of "objectiviness" (Rolf Brednich), of carefully drawing a separation line between our scientific discours and the folklore text (Gary Alan Fine). Otherwise, *our* story may turn against us and be more dangerous, more harmful than the stories it is based on.

I quote from memory one of Bill Nicolaisen's wise sayings: "The past never existed until we narrated it". Now, after telling the story of the 12th International Conference of ISCLR in Paris it became past, a past we'll nostalgicaly recall.

For the newcommers, the ISCLR looked like an esquisite, but not exclusive club of senior researchers who share, for years, their thoughts and ideas, and who know by heart each other's contributions, strong standings and weakenesses. It is why, besides the papers themselves, all of them full of new and valid observations, the discutions and comments offered, very often, an intelectual feast, a banquet to which contributed, among others, Gillian Bennet, Rolf W. Brednich, Gary R. Butler, Véronique Campion-Vincent, Bill Ellis, Gary Alan Fine, Mark Glazer, Sandy Hobbs, Bengt af Klintberg, Bill Nicolaisen, Jacqueline Simpson, Jeff Victor et al.

The Paris Conference will be, for sure, well remembered. For we all enjoyed so much the excellent conditions offered by our French hosts, their grace, courtesy and friendship.

As for Paris, with all its splendours, it remains to be visited some other time!